SUSTAINABILITY TRAINING

Building Strong, Independent Communities

FACILITATOR SESSION GUIDE

Duration 90 – 120 minutes	**Audience** Community groups, NGO staff, project leaders
Language Simple English (accessible for all literacy levels)	**Materials Needed** Flipchart, markers, printed handout (optional)

What Will People Learn?

By the end of this session, everyone should be able to:

- Explain what sustainability means in simple words
- Name the four main ways to build a strong project
- Give one local example for each way
- Start planning their own sustainability steps

Session Plan at a Glance

Time	Part	What Happens
10 min	**Welcome & Warm-Up**	Introductions, icebreaker question about community projects
15 min	**What Is Sustainability?**	Explain the meaning with a simple story
40 min	**Four Ways to Build Sustainability**	Teach each way with real examples
15 min	**Group Activity**	Small groups discuss which ways fit their project
10 min	**Your Sustainability Plan**	Each person writes two action steps

10 min	**Review & Close**	Key messages, questions, next steps

Part 1: Welcome and Warm-Up (10 minutes)

Say This to the Group

"Welcome, everyone! Today we will talk about something very important — how to keep your project strong for a long time, even when outside help ends. This is called sustainability."

Warm-Up Question (Ask the Group)

Ask: *"Think of a community project you know. Is it still working today? Why or why not?"*

Let 2–3 people share. Write key words on the flipchart. This will connect to the lesson.

Part 2: What Is Sustainability? (15 minutes)

Simple Explanation

Say this to the group:

"Sustainability means your project can keep helping people even when the donation or outside money stops. It means you find your own ways to pay for the work."

Tell This Story

Story Example

"There were two gardens in the same village. Garden A got free seeds from an NGO every year. When the NGO left, Garden A had no more seeds. It stopped growing. Garden B also got seeds — but they saved some seeds every year to use next season. When the NGO left, Garden B kept growing. Which garden was sustainable?"

Ask	Which garden is like your project? What can you save or grow for next year?

Part 3: Four Ways to Build Sustainability (40 minutes)

Teach each of the four ways. Spend about 10 minutes on each one.

Way 1 — Making Money (Income Generation)

What It Means (Say This)

"This means you create activities that bring in money. You sell something, charge a small fee, or rent something out. This money helps pay for your project."

Real Example from the Slides

Women's group in Kenya
• Before: They waited for donations
• Now: They make and sell handmade baskets at the market
• They earn $400 per month
• This pays for materials, rent, and small salaries

Facilitator Questions

- What can your group make or sell?
- Is there a service people in your community need and would pay a small fee for?
- What small income activity can you start this month?

Facilitator Tip	Encourage participants to think of things they already do well — cooking, sewing, farming, teaching.

Way 2 — Social Business (Social Enterprise)

What It Means (Say This)

"A social business does two things at the same time: it helps people, and it earns money. The money earned is used to keep helping more people."

Real Example from the Slides

Health center in Uganda
• Problem: People got sick from dirty water
• Solution: They sell water filters at a low price families can afford
• Result: Families have clean water AND the center earns money to pay staff
• The center stays open — no donations needed

Facilitator Questions

- What problem does your project solve?
- Is there a way to solve that problem AND earn a little money at the same time?

- Who would pay a small amount for your service or product?

Facilitator Tip	A social business does not have to be big. Even a very small activity that earns $50 per month is a good start.

Way 3 — Community Help (Community Fundraising)

What It Means (Say This)

"This means you ask people in your own community to help — with money, time, food, or skills. When people give something, they feel the project belongs to them too. They want it to succeed."

Three Ways to Get Community Help

Method	How It Works + Example
Local Events	Hold fun events where people pay to join. Example: A school holds a fun run. People pay $5 to enter. They raise $2,000 for new books.
Membership Programs	Ask people to join and pay a small fee each month or year. Example: A library charges $10 per year. 200 members = $2,000 per year.
Community Gifts	Ask local businesses and families to give what they can — money, food, time, or skills. Example: Farmers donate food for a community meal.

Facilitator Tip	Remind participants: community help is not just money. Time, food, skills, and space also count.

Way 4 — Different Sources (Diversified Funding)

What It Means (Say This)

"Do not put all your eggs in one basket. If you depend on only one donor and they leave, your project stops. Get money from many different places. Then if one source stops, others keep you going."

The Table Leg Idea

Share this simple picture:

✗ One Leg Table	✓ Many Leg Table
One donor stops = project falls	One stops = project still stands

Real Example from the Slides: Rwanda Youth Center

This community group gets money from 5 different sources every month:

Source	Amount	Share
Individual Donations	$3,000	30%
Government Grant	$2,500	25%
Selling Crafts	$2,000	20%
Membership Fees	$1,500	15%
Event Fundraisers	$1,000	10%
TOTAL	**$10,000**	**100%**

Facilitator Questions

- How many sources of money does your project have right now?
- What is one new source you could try this year?

Part 4: Group Activity (15 minutes)

Divide everyone into small groups of 3–5 people. Give each group this task:

Group Task

Think about your own project or a project in your community.
Discuss these questions:

1. Which of the four ways could work for your project?
2. Give one local example for the way you chose.
3. What is the first small step you can take?

Each group will share one idea with everyone.

Facilitator Tip	Walk around and listen. Help groups that are stuck by asking: 'What do people in your community buy or need?'

Part 5: My Sustainability Plan (10 minutes)

Give each person time to write or think about their own two steps. Say:

"Before you leave today, write down two actions you will take. They should be small and specific — something you can do in the next two weeks."

My Action Plan

Name: _____

My project: _____

Step 1 — I will try this way: _____

My specific action: _____

I will do it by (date): _____

Step 2 — I will also try: _____

My specific action: _____

I will do it by (date): _____

Part 6: Review and Close (10 minutes)

Key Messages to Say

Go through these points slowly. Ask the group to say them back to you:

The four ways to build sustainability
✓ Way 1 — Make money through selling or charging small fees
✓ Way 2 — Start a social business that helps people and earns money
✓ Way 3 — Ask your community to help and feel ownership
✓ Way 4 — Use many different money sources so you stay strong

Final Message

"Sustainability means your project can help people for many years to come."

Thank everyone. Ask if there are any questions. Remind them of their two action steps.

Facilitator Quick Notes

✓ Do This	✗ Avoid This
Use local examples from your own area	Using only examples from other countries
Speak slowly and check for understanding	Reading from slides without explaining
Ask questions and let people answer	Talking for too long without a break
Celebrate all ideas, even small ones	Saying an idea is wrong or not good enough
Use simple words, no difficult terms	Using terms like 'revenue streams' or 'diversification'